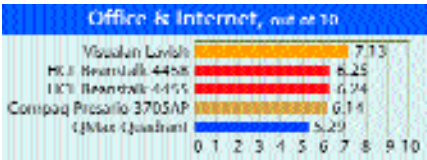


Decision Maker			
	Gaming and Entertainment	Productivity	Office and Internet
You need	To play the latest games such as <i>Quake III Arena</i> and <i>Unreal Tournament 2003</i> at the maximum settings and with all the effects turned on	To work with applications such as Photoshop and with audio and video editing tools	A computer for surfing the Net and that can run day-to-day applications such as word processors and spreadsheets
Look for	At least a 2 GHz processor, 256 MB of DDR RAM, a 40 GB, 7,200-rpm hard disk, a 17-inch flat monitor, 2.1 speakers and at least a 16x DVD-ROM drive	At least a 1.7 GHz processor, 128 MB of DDR RAM, a 40 GB, 7,200-rpm hard disk, and a 17-inch monitor	At least a 1.2 GHz processor, 128 MB of SDRAM, 40 GB hard disk, 15-inch monitor, integrated graphics and sound
The models	Visualan Lavish, HCL Beanstalk 4455, Dart Emerald	HCL Beanstalk 4455, Dart Emerald	HCL Beanstalk 4458, Compaq Presario 3705AP, Visualan Celebrity
Price range	Rs 40,000 to Rs 74,000	Rs 59,990 to Rs 74,000	Rs 27,750 to Rs 48,990

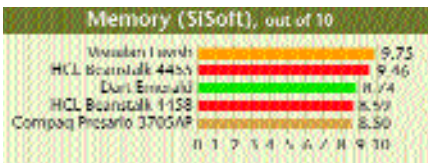
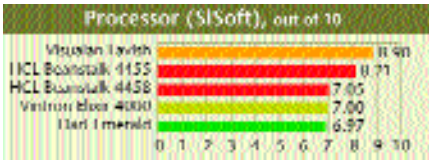
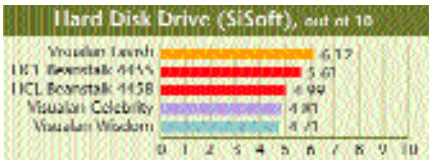
Once again, the computer that excelled was the Visualan Lavish. The two HCL computers competed closely in this category, leading to some very interesting observations. Even though both computers have different specifications, they were equally suited to office suites and Net surfing, as the relevant subsystems that were affected by the tests for this application had nearly similar specifications. Both these systems were based on the Pentium 4 processor with DDR memory, both had a



17-inch monitor with integrated audio. Yet the differences between the Beanstalk 4455 and the Beanstalk 4458 were numerous: the former had a RAID-0 array of 7,200-rpm hard disk drives, while the latter had a simple 5,400-rpm drive. The Beanstalk 4455 had 256 MB of DDR RAM while the 4458 had just 128 MB and even though there was an ASUS V8170 Magic graphics card in the Beanstalk 4455, this made minimal difference in office applications and surfing. Another difference was in the optical drives used—the Beanstalk 4458 had a simple 52x CD-ROM drive, while the Beanstalk 4455 featured a 16x Pioneer DVD drive. The CD-ROM of the Beanstalk 4458 featured a sequential read rate of 2.86 MBps, while the Beanstalk 4455's

DVD drive featured a transfer rate of slightly over 3 MBps. The sound system of the Beanstalk 4458 delivered a very commendable score of 8.83 out of 10, but the Beanstalk 4455 fell significantly under par, managing a score of just 1.88.

Armed with the Pentium 4/DDR combination, the Compaq Presario 3705AP proved to be a good performer for office applications. Despite the fact that it had only a 15-inch monitor, the display was sharp and clear. Its processor enabled this computer to perform well in the SiSoft Sandra sub-test. Its DDR memory also managed a good data transfer rate of 1.7 GBps; particularly impressive was its CD-ROM drive, which managed a sequential read rate of 3.96 MBps, making it the fastest in this comparison.



Buying Tips

- The specifications and associated features of your system configuration need to be suited to your application.
- Verify that a service centre is located close by and you fall within the jurisdiction of the service personnel in case of onsite calls.
- Your system should be capable of supporting newer and faster processors, and must contain adequate vacant slots for RAM and enough USB and serial ports for peripheral devices.
- Take into account how many vacant 5.25-inch drive bays your cabinet has for a future CD-RW drive.
- Enquire about the cost of various upgrade components to get a clear idea for a future budget.
- Find out what finance schemes are available and the flexibility options that exist. Preferably, check if the vendor has tie-ups with your particular bank for easy finance.
- Ask the PC vendor for references or phone numbers of former customers. They are usually more than willing to oblige.



Warranty and support

In evaluating the warranty and support of the computers, the brand that stood head and shoulders above the others was Compaq. With over 1,000 service centres across the country, there is ample support for this computer when you need it. It is also the only brand to offer telephonic customer support and a one-year onsite warranty on the Presario 3705AP. Coming in a close second was HCL, with 500 service centres spread across the country. It too offers a one-year onsite warranty. Vintron's service network is spread across 300 service centres across the country and it specifies an onsite warranty on its computers only within city limits. Dart's service network is spread across 275 service centres across the country and it offers a very impressive three-year onsite warranty. QMAX specifies a one-year carry-in warranty and has 100 service centres across the country. The only disappointing brand in terms of service network support was Visualan—it has only nine service centres in India, but does offer a one-year warranty. All the brands had the provision of an AMC after the warranty period.